banned. So was looking in a mirror. Boys should not be awake after 10 pm. Even saying the words “woman” or “girl” was prohibited. The list of rules for women was even longer: going to the beach alone, owning a mobile phone, looking men in the eye, walking down the street with their father, wearing sneakers—all were forbidden.

This sort of extremism is often swept under the rug, particularly when it relates to sex. There are widespread allegations of child sexual abuse in *haredi* communities, but they often go unreported. Again, there are a few hopeful signs: a new victims’ center in Beit Shemesh has counseled 600 children over the past five years, nearly one-third of them in 2015 alone. Activists, filmmakers and journalists have tried to challenge the taboo. But the rabbis and politicians often duck the issue.

The following summer, an ultra-Orthodox man named Yishai Shlissel would stab six people at the annual gay pride parade in Jerusalem. One of his victims, a 16-year-old girl named Shira Banki, died from her wounds. Shlissel had recently been released from prison after carrying out a similar attack. Inexplicably, the police did not have him under surveillance, even though he had spoken publicly about his plans to carry out another attack against the “abomination”.

A few ultra-Orthodox lawmakers condemned the attack, but others kept silent, and none mentioned the widespread homophobia that caused it. Days later, a *haredi* school in Jerusalem uninvited President Rivlin from a ceremony marking the first day of school because he had strongly condemned the stabbing. And in December, when the Likud swore in its first openly gay Knesset member, none of his ultra-Orthodox coalition partners sat in the plenum to hear his speech. Instead they held a boycott.

Less than the sum of its parts

Race, religion, economics: these are not usually the subjects that make the foreign media headlines about Israel. And yet they are perhaps a greater long-term challenge than the stagnant Israeli-Palestinian conflict.

Modern-day Israel often seems less like a state and more like an unhappy amalgamation of tribes (which will be discussed later in the book). The rifts are particularly stark between Jews and Arabs. In the eyes of the Jewish state, the Druze are an ideal minority. They serve loyally in the army, they overwhelmingly identify as Israeli, and often even as Zionists. (I’ve met